

Saehan's MPMan

was the world's first mass-produced hardware MP3 player.



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TRIED & TESTED

available for research and development, this does not hold true all the time. You can also get multiple products with immensely variable feature sets for the same price, which further adds to the confusion. For example, a compact PMP from a large brand without any sort of display might be available at the same price point as a product from a smaller, lesser-known manufacturer that can play videos and has a two-inch display for the same. Now where do you invest your money? Hopefully, by the time you're done reading this test, you won't be confused.

PMPs up to Rs. 5,000: a diverse bunch

When we look at this category, the first thing that comes to mind is diversity. Some of these players had very tiny, single-colour displays, while others had much larger displays capable of being used as video PMPs albeit without the joy that comes from watching movies on a larger screen like the screen on the Cowon Q5W; which at five inches is one of the largest screens ever to grace a PMP. One of the PMPs in this category had no display at all. That's diversity for you. The divide seemed to be the brand name. Bigger brands (typically) charge more for their products and as such most of the PMPs from larger brands had fewer features for the price. While talking about basic music capable PMPs, even a screen can be considered a "feature", because it's not necessarily required for audio playback. Therefore, the binary choice available here seems to be between paying extra for a more reputed brand and making do with a very cursory display unit (or no display at all) or pay a

little less proportionately and get a video-based PMP that brings more of a feature set to the party.

This is also one of the most important categories in terms of consumers because 90 per cent of shoppers looking for a PMP will be looking to spend no more than this amount. Features become a premium, as does storage space when constrained by a budget of not more than Rs 5,000. Everybody wants more inbuilt memory, but not everybody will actually be using the extra space. For example, many people buy a PMP with 4 GB of memory and then promptly use it for storing some 50-odd favourite tracks and move on to using the FM radio component the most. That way, approximately 3.5 GB of extra space is wasted. Other people choose to purchase a PMP with a screen, when they only use the player for audio playback and a screen is not required. Obviously, purchasing is a decision best left to the one parting with the funds, but all we're saying is to buy what you need and do not splurge needlessly.

Features

The tiniest player in this category is Apple's iPod Shuffle. It's very well built with an all aluminium outer body that is available in a number of tasteful colours. Some may find electric pink and sea blue gaudy, but we



Philips GoGear SA2825

like it. These colours are very understandable for a product mainly aimed at college kids and those looking for something really funky looking. To save on space the Shuffle doesn't even have a display. What it does have are very clear and easy-to-use controls. The four buttons for volume up / down and next / previous track are shaped to form a circle with the large play / pause button in the centre of it. The layout of these buttons

How We Tested



We divided our test candidates into two categories on the basis of their all-important price. The first category consisted of PMPs priced up to Rs. 5,000. The second category consisted of PMPs priced above Rs. 5,000. Since we were only interested in the players' capabilities at audio playback, we discounted the presence of any sort of screen. Screen quality along with any other display-related parameters were only logged and not taken into account when computing results for a winner. We took special note of memory upgradeability, presence of customisable equalisers and integrated FM radio.

Our reference system's source was an iPod Touch 16 GB with files encoded in the Apple lossless audio codec (ALAC) format. We used a Little Dot Micro Tube hybrid headphone amplifier along with Grado's SR 225 and Audio Technica's ATH A900 headphones. The A900 is known for its vast sound stage, slightly laid back presentation and its thundering bass along with a slightly revealing top-end. The Grado SR 225, on the other hand, has a very forward sound that places you right up to the music, something like a front row seat. It is also endowed with good bass, an excellent and very open mid-range and a treble that is both very revealing and extends well into the upper echelons of the audible sonic spectrum. Together with the head amp, these headphones give a very unbiased, audiophile-grade look at the performance of these PMPs. We also used bundled earphones with these players and their performance was rated against the performance of PMPs with respect to our reference headphones.

For our performance testing, we used MP3 files encoded at very high quality settings, at a bit-rate of 320 Kbps keeping the bit-rate constant. These files were a mix of tracks from different genres, each of them testing different aspects of the audible sonic spectrum. Metallica's ~Unforgiven 2~ is a good track to test a PMP's performance in complex passages. It is also a guitar-and-drum heavy track that also tests the mid-range while emphasising drum and bass. Additionally, male vocals are tested. Dire Straits' ~Private Investigation~ tests mainly the mid-range with particular emphasis on lead and rhythm guitar. It tests for tonal accuracy of guitar notes and the very texture of the notes themselves. Pink Floyd's ~Money~ is one track that tests instruments and sound staging in addition to sound panning. The Corrs' rendition of R.E.M.'s ~Everybody Hurts~ is a beautiful test of female vocals as Andrea Corr is one of the better female vocalists around. ~Knockin on Heaven's Door~ by Eric Clapton does more testing of male vocals and guitar rendition. It has a lot of delicate finger plucks and some very articulate notes and we have checked for any sort of sound aberration.



Creative Zen Stone Plus